

will long be felt throughout all England. The Government of India has in its power, and no doubt will carefully provide that, however widely the railway system may be extended in this Empire in the time to come, these great evils should be averted."

Little did he know that these "great evils" would make a comeback nearly two decades after he had left India, turning the country's railways lines into a hotch-potch of gauges. The challenging process of standardizing the gauges would only begin in the 1990s with [Project Unigauge](#).

A case for different gauges

Dalhousie left India in 1856 and by the 1860s, strong advocates for narrower gauge lines emerged.

They refuted earlier safety concerns and instead extolled the advantages of the narrow gauge, including the low cost of construction and maintenance. They also noted the advantages of building these lines in areas that could not profit from the more expensive broad-gauge lines.

The Indian Branch Railway Company was one of the first to build a line on a smaller gauge. Built at a cheaper cost, this special 4ft-gauge ran from the East Indian Railway's (EIR) Nalhati station to Azimgunj (in present-day West Bengal), and opened to traffic in December 1863. The EIR took over the line in 1872 and altered it to broad gauge. In 1865, the Indian Tramway Company opened a line from Arakkonam to Little Conjeevaram in Madras on a 3 ft 6 in gauge, which was converted to a metre gauge in 1878.

The British Government in India agreed to allow for a break in the gauge, as long as it was provisional, and would not compete with the standard broad gauge. In 1869, Lord Lawrence, the Viceroy of India (1864–69), initiated a serious discussion with the British administration in London on gauge change in a detailed minute. The railways were in a terrible financial condition. Building the lines had been expensive as had been their maintenance, and the profits were small. While acknowledging the importance of the expansion of lines, he wrote that it was important to at least consider adopting narrower gauges in some